

Hungary



Area 35,919 sq miles
(93,030 sq km)
Population 10 million
Capital Budapest
Currency Forint
Official language Hungarian
Life expectancy 74 years



Hungary, lying at the heart of central Europe, is a landlocked nation sharing borders with seven countries. The majority of the population is of Magyar ethnicity, with small minorities of Roma, Germans, Jews, Romanians, Serbs, Slovaks, and Croats. With many state-of-the-art factories, Hungary has high industrial production.



▲ **HUNGARIAN PULI**
The fun-loving and intelligent Puli dog originated in Hungary. Traditionally a herding dog, the Puli's corded coat gives it a distinctive appearance.

Romania



Area 91,699 sq miles
(237,500 sq km)
Population 21.4 million
Capital Bucharest
Currency New Romanian leu
Official language Romanian
Life expectancy 72 years



Romania lies on the Black Sea coast, with the Danube River forming its southern border. The Carpathian Mountains run across the center of the country. Romania has large oil reserves, and is currently trying to find natural oil and gas deposits in the Black Sea. It joined the EU in 2007, and plans to adopt the Euro in 2015.

Moldova



Area 13,067 sq miles
(33,843 sq km)
Population 3.5 million
Capital Chisinau
Currency Moldovan leu
Official language Moldovan
Life expectancy 71 years

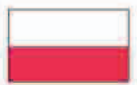


Moldova was part of Romania until 1940, when it became part of the USSR (a Communist state that incorporated Russia and 14 other Soviet republics). Moldova is now Europe's poorest country and depends on Russia for raw materials and fuel. A high proportion of Moldovans are farmers.

Poland



Area 120,728 sq miles
(312,685 sq km)
Population 38.3 million
Capital Warsaw
Currency Polish zloty
Official language Polish
Life expectancy 75 years



Poland extends from the shores of the Baltic Sea on the north coast to the Tatra Mountains in the south. Since the collapse of Communism in Poland in 1989, the country has undergone massive social and political changes, and has experienced rapid economic growth.



▲ **EUROPEAN BISON**
The European bison is the largest living land animal in Europe. The Białowieża Forest in Poland is home to about 800 of these animals.

Czech Republic



Area 30,450 sq miles
(78,866 sq km)
Population 10.5 million
Capital Prague
Currency Czech koruna
Official language Czech
Life expectancy 77 years



Landlocked in central Europe, the Czech Republic consists of the territories of Bohemia and Moravia. Previously part of Czechoslovakia, it became an independent republic in 1993. Czechs make up 90 percent of the population, and Moravians make up the next largest group.



▲ **LEAD CRYSTAL CHANDELIER**
Glassmaking is an important industry in the Czech Republic, where glassmakers are famous for skilled craftsmanship and elaborate designs.

Slovakia



Area 18,859 sq miles
(48,845 sq km)
Population 5.5 million
Capital Bratislava
Currency Euro
Official language Slovak
Life expectancy 75 years



Slovakia was the less developed half of Czechoslovakia for much of the 20th century. It became an independent democracy in 1993 and joined the EU in 2004. The country has since experienced major economic growth, helped by its highly skilled, cheap labor force.